Discussion Round Middle Stage

Substantive Contributions

Over the course of 60 minutes, there are two primary components that make up a round of Discussion: procedural and substantive.

- **Procedural** components provide structure and order to the round, but do not directly contribute ideas or thoughts aimed at solving the task. Examples include setting an agenda, focusing the group, and timing.
- **Substantive** components provide ideas and thoughts in order to solve the task. These involve contributing research or anecdotal evidence, or synthesizing multiple viewpoints.

The middle stage of a Discussion round generally follows the structure decided upon during the initial phase – typically via an agenda, and/or a consensus question. This stage is mostly substantive, as your group should know WHAT you are trying to solve, and HOW you are going to solve it.

This stage of the round doesn't have very many mechanical elements. However, you may hear a few terms which are procedural and control the mechanics of this portion of the round to a certain degree:

1. Re-clarifications
2. Background

These mechanical elements take place immediately after the research period, and so serve as a bridge between the end of the opening stage, and the start of the middle stage. Neither are required, but they are frequently performed. Definitions for both were covered in the Discussion Round Opening Stage - Mechanics and Structure.

Since this is a highly dynamic portion of the round, and largely dictated by the requirements of the task, the rest of this document presents activities which you should attempt to perform throughout this stage of the round.

Contribute Research and Insights

Never stay silent too long. Contribute findings from your research often. Contribute your insights into the discussion frequently. Remember to verbally cite your sources with at least the publication source and date. Be sure that your contributions follow the flow of the conversation, and that you don't accidentally bring up a point that's already been made; or derail the discussion by introducing a completely different topic that wasn't where your group was currently at in the round. Both factual and anecdotal evidence are permitted, but try to have at least an equal balance between the two. Any factual evidence where you cite a source will always trump a contribution based largely on experience or storytelling. However, sometimes those anecdotes can provide emotional and impact beyond just numbers and statistics.

Contributing research and insights is the most substantive contribution you can make in any discussion round!

Take Notes

Bring a notepad and pen to rounds. Try to keep track of the major topics discussed, and who said them (so you can give credit). Essential to have notes in order to Synthesize or Summarize (to be covered by Discussion Round Final Stage - Summary and Synthesis). Make sure you don't keep your head down too long while taking notes, though. See Mind Your Body Language (below). A judge often will note students who are taking notes as good listeners.

Time (Round/Research/Agenda Periods)

Have a way to time your round to prevent running out of time (60 minutes). Offer to time the research period. If you have specific periods of your agenda that are to be timed, offer to time those as well. While this is a procedural contribution, it is still valuable to have someone timing the round and the research so the group doesn't run out of time.

Include Others

If there are less vocal members of the group, verbally try to include them in the round. When you have a chance to talk, make your point, then ask if the quiet person has anything to contribute. This is an easy way to increase favorability with your judge, but it can also be seen as too heavy handed if you do it frequently. Calling quiet students out by name can sometimes feel like you're isolating them from the group. Rather than including others by name, when you get to the end of an important part of the task, ask the group if there are any other insights anyone wants to make before moving on.

Focus the Group

When your group has veered off topic, speak up and point this out. Be ready to offer a suggestion for how to get back on topic. In order to know that you are off topic, rely on your understanding of the task from Analyzing Task (see above). In order to keep track of your Discussion round, be sure to have good notes from Taking Notes (see above).

Mind Your Body Language

How you present yourself physically in Discussion matters. Judges are not only listening and writing down what everyone says, but they are also paying attention to what you do in the round. Show active listening skills when not speaking:

- Lean forward, don't slouch back.
- Try not to tap the table with your pen/pencil.
- Avoid bouncing your legs.
- Facial expressions can be easily mis-interpreted - don't show your frustration on your face! Eye rolling, blowing out air from your lips, frowning, etc. can all give clues that you are frustrated and can be a point the judge marks you down over.
- Nod and make eye contact with whomever is speaking. Avoid audible acknowledgements while actively listening - like saying 'uh-huh' when another student makes a point.
- While taking notes or typing on your computer, be sure to look up and make eye contact with the speaker frequently.
- ***NEVER make eye contact with your judge!***

Mind Your Language

It is important to remember that Discussion is a more business-like category. It often asks you to assume a role that is not a high school student. Be mindful that judges often expect you to sound more professional and less casual. Keep colloquialisms, slang, and pop culture references to a minimum, unless the task is specific to some current cultural event, celebrity, trend, etc.

Avoid fillers like 'um', 'uh', 'y'know', etc. When you speak, make your point as concise as possible. Try to sound as professional and composed as possible.

Try not to break the imaginary 4th wall either, once you start the round. Don't mention that you're high schoolers, this is a Discussion activity, or anything that would indicate you're no longer in that role the task asks you to be (the WHO of the task).

Mind Your Volume

Also be really careful with your volume. We often compete in gymnasiums which host 10-15 other discussion tables simultaneously. It is very hard to hear in these spaces, and so you need to always be louder than you normally would be when speaking casually.

When we speak casually, we tend to drop volume at the end of sentences. This frequently ends with us vocally fraying the last few words in a sentence. This is interpreted when in dialogue as an invitation for the other person in the conversation to start speaking. Pay attention to this typical behavior when talking with your peers - we often jump in and start talking when the other person's volume dips. In a Discussion round, when you drop your volume, this almost always invites someone else jumping in and interrupting the end of your point, because that is naturally what we are all used to doing.

Manage Conflicts & Interruptions

Sometimes it is hard to be able to find an opportunity to speak. Often multiple speakers attempt to jump in at the same time, and a conflict arises to determine speaking order. You may find yourself getting cut off by others while you have the floor. These are all very common, and can easily lead to frustration.

In situations where multiple speakers try to jump in at the same time, a few strategies can be used here:

1. Raise your volume and keep going, essentially ignoring and cutting off the other speaker(s) trying to talk. You have to be very careful when using this tactic, overusing it in a round can be detrimental to your rankings. This can work when there are more than 2 speakers attempting to go at the same time. One thing that can soften the blow of this tactic is if you can make your point very concise, and then acknowledge that the other speaker had been attempting to speak, and give them the ground.
2. Acknowledge the other speaker(s) attempting to speak with you, and ask if they wouldn't mind going right after you. This is a more polite way to get to speak first, but you have to make sure that the speaker you suggest goes after you, does go after you. While this is more polite, doing this often can also lead to negative impressions of you by the judge. Similar to the first strategy, you should avoid always using this strategy, and balance it with the third strategy below.
3. Acknowledge the other speaker(s) attempting to speak with you, give ground and let them go, but ask them if you can go right after they do. This is the most polite way of handling a conflict, but it usually means you will miss your chance to contribute. That said, this can be a way to balance out times when you might have been the one going first. Use this if you find yourself frequently interrupting others and speaking before they do (strategies 1, 2, & 4).
4. Indicate that your point is directly in response to the previous speaker's point, and politely suggest you should go next. This is similar to the second strategy, where you are acknowledging other speakers attempting to go, and then proceeding to go. The difference here is you are justifying your need to be the interruptor by demonstrating a

direct lineage to the last point made. This sense of urgency can be the most powerful way to get the floor next. It has a lot of the same potential negative connotations that strategies 1 and 2 have, so try to not use this a lot in a round, and balance it with strategy 3.

While speaking casually to each other, it is natural that we cut each other off when we sense the other person is coming to a conclusion. See the Mind Your Volume about how volume at the ends of sentences is usually the way speakers interpret you're getting close to the end of your point. In Discussion this can be a source of friction. There are really two ways to handle this situation when you are still talking but another speaker tries to cut you off:

1. Keep your volume consistent through the ends of your sentences. This is a preventative measure to being cut off. It won't always work, but it is the best defense to being cut off continuously in a round.
2. When being cut off, raise your volume and politely state that you haven't finished making your point. Acknowledge they want to speak, and if there isn't already someone designated as being the next speaker, suggest they can go after you. Be sure to let that person go after you when you do finish your point.